S O M a 1

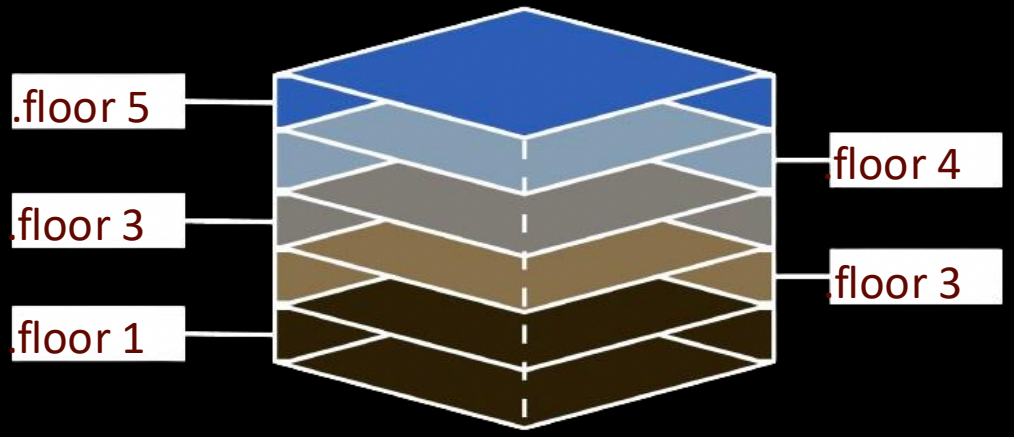
- The lost arc -

Introduction

Soma 1 is a fictional space station a cube assembled in orbit, home to a sealed society that has been drifting through space for longer than anyone aboard can truly remember. Originally launched as a revered arc mission to carry life to new worlds, the ship lost its course and never arrived. It is entirely self-contained: food, water, power, and waste all cycle through the same closed loop, and nobody has left since the route was lost.

The culture and structure of Soma 1 are shaped by a single governing principle: maintain the ship. What began as practical necessity has calcified over generations into something more total; a society so thoroughly organised around function that the original purpose of the mission has become, for most people aboard, an abstraction. We find Soma 1 vastly into an unseen future, millions of years from now.

S t r u c t u r e



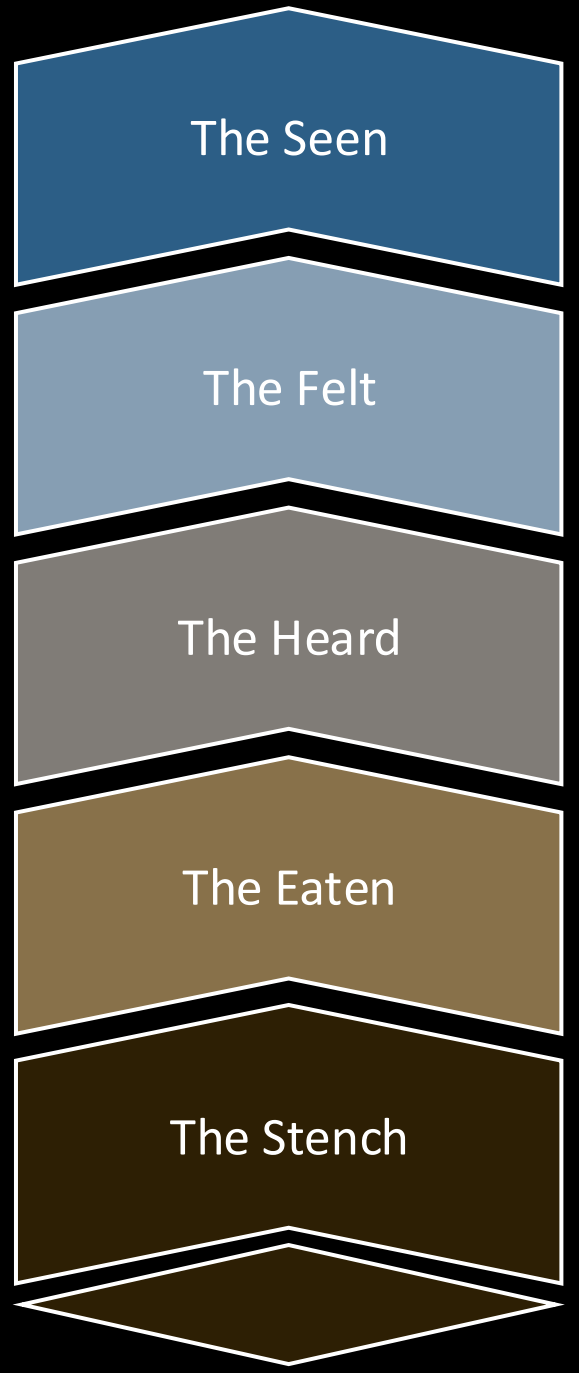
Soma 1 is a cube. five floors stacked inside a 5km hull, each built around the work that happens there rather than the people doing it. The ship was assembled in low orbit over fourteen years, fitted floor by floor from the inside out as the outer hull closed around it. By the time the final hull panels were sealed, the lowest floor had already been occupied for three years.

- **Floor 5, The Seen:** Governance, surveillance infrastructure, and the original launch archive. Highest air quality, highest light, largest individual space allocations on the ship.
- **Floor 4, The Felt:** Enforcement, access control, and communication hub. All inter-floor pressure doors are operated from this level.
- **Floor 3, The Heard:** Mixed residential and administrative functions. Medical, record keeping, and the distribution of processed rations before they move downward.
- **Floor 2, The Eaten:** Full-spectrum hydroponic grow stations, fungal bays, food processing, and manufacturing. The warmest floor on the ship, the grow lights never go off.
- **Floor 1, The Stench:** Excrement combustion, urine filtration, ventilation control, and hull inspection. Built around the ship's infrastructure. The corridors are narrow because the machinery needed the space first.

Social Hierarchy

There are five castes on Soma 1, each named for a sense, and each tied to a floor. At the top, The Seen govern and surveil. Below them, The Felt enforce. The Heard occupy the middle, the only caste permitted to move between floors, carrying information downward and logging everything. The Eaten run the farms and workshops on Floor 2. At the base, The Stench maintain the combustion units, filter the water, and keep the ship breathing.

Nobody moves up. The only direction the system allows is down. A floor reassignment is permanent: your caste designation updates in the record, your family does not follow unless they choose to, and choosing to is itself logged. The threat of descent is the mechanism that holds everything in place.



History & Power

Soma 1 launched with optimism , deep institutional blues and cold silvers, the visual vocabulary of a civilisation that believed it was going somewhere. At some point after losing course, the ship experienced a period of anarchy before order was established. The caste structure that emerged from that collapse was not designed by any one person. It calcified out of existing divisions of labour, visibility, and resource access, the same way hierarchies always do.

The Seen are the only caste with access to the original launch archive. Current population is estimated between 35,000 and 40,000, records have not been independently verified in six generations. The founding rule has not changed. Everything else has accumulated around it.

S o c i e t y

The upper floors are quiet and controlled, with filtered light from the Solarterium above and spaces that are uncrowded if not quite luxurious. Floor 2 is loud, warm, and permanently lit by the grow station lamps running their artificial cycle, the air smells of soil and green things, which is either pleasant or suffocating depending on how long you've been breathing it. Floor 1 is dark, hot near the combustion units, cold everywhere else, built around the ship's pipes rather than its people.

Family structures are practical before anything else. You pair within your floor, not because there is a rule against otherwise, but because you never meet anyone from another floor. Children are registered at birth, assigned the caste of their floor, and raised collectively on the lower levels out of necessity, because shifts are long and the work does not stop.

B e l i e f

There is no official religion on Soma 1, the governing logic is that the ship requires work, not worship. Several small sects have developed independently across the floors without the acknowledgement of the upper castes. They are not banned. The Seen consider being ignored more effective than persecution.

The most widespread belief in the lower floors is that the Outside is somewhere good, somewhere light reaches, somewhere you could breathe air that hasn't already been breathed. Nobody alive has seen it. A minority view in the middle floors holds that the Outside is not a place but an ending. And one fringe cult, the only religious movement the Seen actually monitor, has concluded that if the ship is a body, the Stench are its blood, and therefore more essential than those who govern.

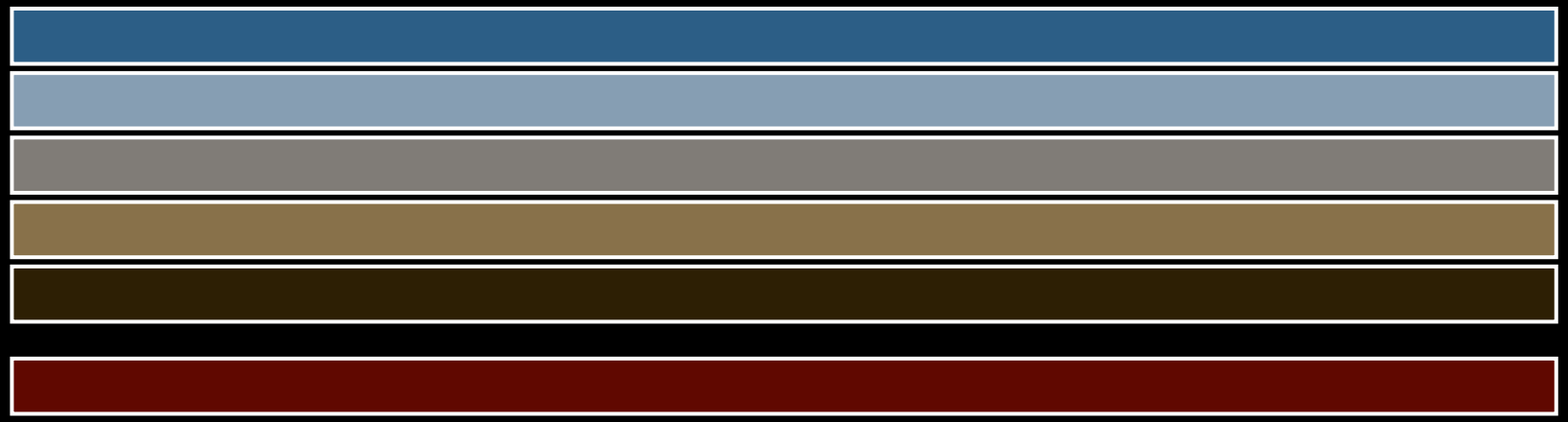
Physics & Language

Soma 1 runs on fusion power supplemented by the combustion of organic waste. Two of the four original reactors failed in the first century; the remaining two operate at reduced capacity, cannibalised for parts from the failed units for generations. The water cycle is fully closed, urine filtered to drinking water, returned upward through the pipe network. It is the one system aboard that has never failed. This is known. It is not discussed.

There are no seasons and no natural light below Floor 4. The ship's internal clock is maintained exclusively by The Heard. Time, like everything else on Soma 1, is a resource held by the people above.

Visual Language

The visual language of Soma 1 is read top to bottom like the ship itself, deep institutional blue at the peak, the colour of a civilisation that believed it was going somewhere, bleeding down through cold grey, warm brown, and finally the near-black of something that has been burning for a very long time. Signage, uniforms, and infrastructure all carry this palette by floor, so even without words, you know where you are and what that means. Red is reserved for Root, the outside, the origin, appearing only as a detail, a warning, or an absence.



Narrative

Soma 1 sits naturally in the YA tradition, the locked-in society, the caste you're born into, the question of whether the system can be broken. It could work as a novel told in five parts, one per floor, the same week, five entirely different realities assembled by the reader. It could also work as a tabletop game where players are assigned castes at random, each floor chasing its own objective with no direct communication, everything routed through The Heard, who are also players at the table.

A graphic novel following a child reassigned downward at age twelve, told entirely without dialogue, just the architecture changing around her as she descends. A short story following a Stench engineer on a routine hull inspection who finds something the official record says cannot be there. The world is built for stories about people who cannot leave, and what that does to them over time.

M o o d



